

Meganeura

Possibly the largest insect that has ever lived, *Meganeura* looked like a gigantic dragonfly. Its wingspan was 2½ ft (75 cm)—12 times greater than that of common dragonflies today. This monster insect used its giant wings to hunt other insects in midair. Insects and other invertebrates grew to a great size in the lush forests of the Carboniferous Period, perhaps because Earth's air was richer in oxygen than today, making breathing easier.

